

Looking For Trouble

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If you've been following these pages closely (and we hope you have), you'll have noticed that we've talked a lot about security—it's a huge concern for any organisation, and it's something that requires constant attention. If you've been taking our advice then, you ought to have an effective security solution in place for your office. Or do you?

You see, implementing security solutions and policies is only the first step. Every once in a while, you need to verify that your security solution is doing what it's supposed to. Perhaps more importantly, you also need to know whether everyone in your team is following the security policies you've so lovingly prepared.

Check-up Time

To ensure that everything's all right with your security arrangements, you need to conduct a security audit. There's no strict definition for

the term, but like any other audit, the basic idea is to examine the truth of a claim—the claim, in this case, being that you're safe from security threats. You might think that "Security Audit" is just a glorified term for sitting with a checklist—to a certain extent, it is. However, the seemingly mundane task of checking items off your list will let you know where you're going wrong with security, and help you formulate a better solution.

In the corporate world, security audits are carried out by a crack team of experts, who usually come at a fee that can run close to a lakh for a single consultancy. While some aspects of an audit can only be performed by security experts, you can do a fairly effective—and very cheap—audit yourself, too.

The Elements

So how does one go about a security audit, anyway? Simply put, it's like we mentioned—knowing how your security solution should work, and checking to see if that's how it's working. It's very important, then, to put your security policy down on paper—which programs are allowed to run on PCs, which users get access to which resources on your network, and so on.

Think you've secured your office well? Time to put your money where your mouth is

Then comes the risk assessment—figuring out how important a security issue is. Consider the scenario that a laptop is stolen. On a scale of 0 to 10, the probability of this scenario is, say, 3. Now, on a scale of 0 to 10 again, the damage this scenario could cause is, say, 8. The risk of a particular scenario is the product of the probability that it occurs and the damage it could cause if it did. The higher the risk, the more measures you'll need to take to bring it down. The numbers expressed here are random—you'll have to assess your own situation (how scatterbrained is the employee with the laptop, and so on) and arrive at your own values. There's no formula involved here, and it's far from an exact science. The idea of the risk assessment is more to help you prioritise tasks.

But we get ahead of ourselves here. First, we need to prepare for the audit.

Groundwork

This is where we prepare our checklists, starting with the company's assets—PCs, printers, laptops, cameras, e-mails, passwords and so on—pretty much anything that can be threatened by unnamed malicious forces. This list should be detailed—model numbers, serial numbers, and so on.

Once you're done cataloguing your assets, it's time to assess the threats you might face. Common threats are stolen passwords, falling prey to a phishing e-mail, stolen or misplaced laptops and PDAs, and so on. If you can think of a threat, put it on the list—no matter how silly it sounds (once you start calculating risks, the less likely threats will find themselves low on your priority list anyway).

You should also know your security history—when was the last time you faced a security issue? How much damage did it do? Have you taken appropriate measures to ensure it doesn't happen again? Keep tabs on security trends in the small business / SoHo sector as well—they'll give you an idea of currently prevalent threats, and will likely lengthen your threat list.

Finally, take your threat list and calculate the risk of each threat. Now, you can begin your audit. We'll only go through some of the more common threats here.

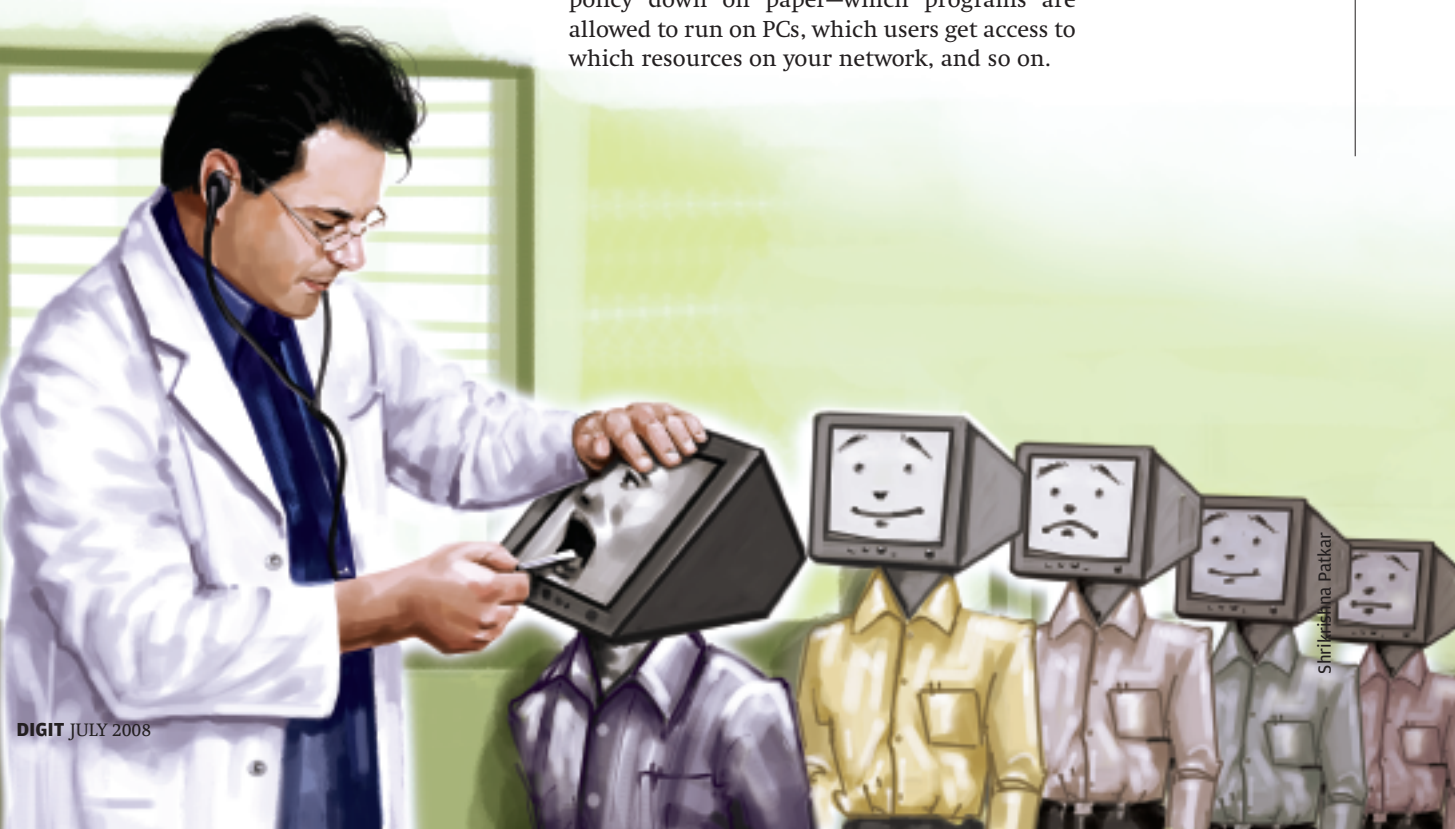
Auditing Access

When you're not controlling who has access to what data, you've got yourself a problem. A visitor could walk away with your list of clients, for example, and you'd be none the wiser. An ideal situation would be to set up a domain controller (*Digit* February 2007). Failing that, you should ensure that all shared folders are password protected, and are accessible only by specific users—this means turning on Advanced Folder Sharing under Tools > Folder Options > View in Windows Explorer, and editing the permissions on shared folders. Furthermore, use dollar-shares—append a "\$" at the end of the share name.

Another thing you want to look out for is automatic logins—while convenient, it's more than unadvisable to allow a PC to automatically log in to a user's account. Should the wrong person be seated in front of that PC, it could possibly give him administrative access. In the same vein, network passwords shouldn't be saved on a PC—go to Start > Run. Type `control userpasswords2` and press [Enter]. In the Manage Passwords tab, make sure the list is empty. Ditto e-mail passwords—both in the e-mail client and on the Web. Finally, ensure that when a PC is left unattended, it's screen is locked ([Windows] + [L]).

Auditing Applications

The next threat comes from installed applications that shouldn't really be installed. Most often, these are instant messaging (IM)



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